

Sustainable Materials & Market Intelligence Briefing

Saturday, 10 October 2026 — prepared for Amy, KAESA

1. Headline: The PFAS Deadline Is Today — and Korea's Sustainable Leather Numbers Just Got Interesting

Two things land on the same day, and they point the same direction.

Regulation (EU) 2024/2462 — the PFHxA restriction under REACH — applies from **10 October 2026** to textiles, leather, furs and hides used in clothing and accessories, plus all footwear for the general public. The limits: 25 ppb for PFHxA and its salts, 1,000 ppb for related substances, measured in homogeneous material. It widens on 10 October 2027 beyond apparel and accessories. The one genuine buffer: it does not apply to products placed on the market before the application date. That protects stock already sold in. It does not protect anything you are about to order.

Source: <https://www.bdlaw.com/publications/new-eu-pfhxa-limits-take-effect-amid-expanding-pfas-rules-for-apparel-and-textiles/>

This is the narrow restriction. The class-wide PFAS ban is broader and slower: ECHA's risk assessment committee adopted its final opinion in March 2026, SEAC's is due by end of 2026, and first bans land in 2029 at the earliest. France has moved ahead of all of it — since 1 January 2026 French law bans PFAS in consumer clothing and footwear, with the stock-clearance window closing 31 December 2026.

Source: <https://projetcelsius.com/en/blog/pfas-ban-france-eu/>

The strategic read for KAESA: the durable answer is a PFAS-free DWR and coating decision made at the **tier-2 level**, not certificate-chasing on finished goods. France's thresholds apply to fluoropolymers too, so a single PTFE membrane is enough to put a consumer item out of compliance. That decision made in 2026 costs a season. Made in 2029, it costs a collection.

2. Materials & Innovation

- **Leap® apple-waste material reaches 91% USDA-certified biobased** — made from apple waste on a European supply chain, validated by CATAS, Eurofins and Intertek, and already adopted by European accessories brands. The certification is the marketable part.

Source: <https://www.explore-leap.com/leap-slg-bags-accessories>

- **Leafy Leather hits 99% bio-based, USDA BioPreferred certified** — agro-waste and renewable plant feedstock, third-party verified. The highest certified figure I have seen in the plant-leather category.

Source: <https://leafyleather.com/leafy-leather-99-bio-based-and-usda-biopreferred-certified/>

- **AAMATI: ~50% mango biomass leather, tested to 12 ISO/SATRA parameters** — abrasion beyond 35,000 Martindale cycles and cold-crack at -10°C. Patented in India, filed in Europe and the US, already cut into handbags.

Source: <https://www.premierevision.com/en/articles/36087eb9-4287-f111-b337-000d3a3a1397/aamati-the-biodegradable-luxury-leather-grown-in-india-s-mango-orchards>

- **MIRUM® plus mycelium: a 100% bio-based, plastic-free bag exists today** — Melina Bucher's DREAMER combines MIRUM® (FSC-certified natural rubber), Ecovative Forager® mycelium foam, BioPuff® Typha fibre and hemp-residue reinforcement.

Source: https://melinabucher.com/cdn/shop/files/Introducing_DREAMER_EN.pdf?v=6357902814087362278

- **Brightplus and Leaf Bio: 100% bio-based PEF textile laminate, no separate adhesive** — a two-layer concept collapsing the usual three components into two. Debuts at Performance Days Munich, 13–14 October.

No waterproofness or peel-strength figures published — treat as directional.

Source:

<https://textalks.com/brightplus-and-leaf-bio-develop-bio-based-textile-laminate-without-separate-adhesive/>

3. Policy & Regulation

- **EmpCo greenwashing rules are live, with no transition period** — Directive (EU) 2024/825 has applied since 27 September 2026. It blacklists generic environmental claims ("eco-friendly", "green") unless the trader can demonstrate recognised excellent environmental performance, bans offset-based product neutrality claims, and bans sustainability labels not backed by a public authority or qualifying certification scheme.

Source: <https://www.weil.com/-/media/files/pdfs/2026/september/weil-eu-empco-briefing-september-2026.pdf>

- **Old stock is not exempt, but enforcement is phased** — the CPC Network's June 2026 Common Understanding lets national authorities take a proportionate approach where genuine transitional difficulties exist, naming stickering or point-of-sale correction as interim fixes. Penalties reach at least 4% of annual turnover, or €2m minimum.

Source: <https://www.stblaw.com/about-us/publications/view/2026/09/30/the-eu-empco-directive-new-greenwashing-rules-now-in-force>

- **The claims that will bite are on hangtags and collection names** — EmpCo reaches imagery, colour schemes, brand names and product names, not just body copy. A "sustainable" category filter is a claim about every product inside it.

Source: <https://www.bluesign.com/empco-what-brands-can-say>

- **France's PFAS stock window closes 31 December 2026** — products containing PFAS made before 1 January 2026 may be placed on market only until then. After it, already-marketed stock may be resold, but no new placement. The 2030 extension covers all textiles.

Source: <https://www.twobirds.com/en/insights/2026/france/pfas-et-produits-textiles--une-interdiction-progressive-aux-implications-majeures-pour-les-acteurs-d>

- **Textile DPP horizon unchanged: delegated act Q4 2027, application around 2029** — the Commission's textile page now shows Q4 2027, and EN 18219:2026 and EN 18220:2026 were published 15 July 2026.

Source: https://single-market-economy.ec.europa.eu/single-market/digital-product-passport/textile-apparel_en

- **The compliance bottleneck is tier 2–3, not tier 1** — JRC report 145830 anticipates roughly 35 mandatory datapoints per reference, with 60–70% residing at spinning, weaving and dyeing suppliers rather than with the brand.

Source: <https://www.traceweave.eu/en/resources/blog/pasaporte-digital-producto-textil-espr-manual-tecnico>

4. Market Intelligence

- **Global luxury handbags: USD 28.57bn in 2026 to USD 38.13bn by 2031, 5.94% CAGR** — offline retail held 63.80% of channel share in 2025, but online is growing at 7.54% CAGR.

Source: <https://www.mordorintelligence.com/industry-reports/luxury-handbag-market>

- **Asia-Pacific is both the largest and the fastest-growing region** — 44.13% of market share in 2025, growing at 7.46% CAGR, with China, Japan, South Korea and India named as key demand centres.

Source: <https://www.mordorintelligence.com/industry-reports/luxury-handbag-market>

- **Korea: USD 451.65m in 2025 to USD 766.25m by 2034 — and Sustainable Leather is the largest material type** — the number worth putting in front of the board. Korea's luxury handbag market is segmented by material, and Sustainable Leather led on size in 2025 while also forecast to grow fastest. Sustainability is not a

niche here; it is the largest segment.

Source: <https://deepmarketinsights.com/vista/insights/luxury-handbag-market/korea>

- **Korea's market structure favours the sustainability angle** — 70–80% of unit volume is imported, and premium and luxury account for 35–45% of market value. Korean consumers already pay KRW 500,000 or more for recognised labels, with sustainability and ethical sourcing named as increasingly important purchase criteria.

Source:

<https://www.indexbox.io/store/republic-of-korea-handbags-market-analysis-forecast-size-trends-and-insights/>

- **Material risk is named explicitly for your category** — tighter leather traceability requirements and rising scrutiny of animal-derived and exotic-skin materials are listed among the main pressures on luxury handbag companies.

Source: <https://www.mordorintelligence.com/industry-reports/luxury-handbag-market>

5. For Your Radar

- **Run a claims audit this week, not next quarter.** The fastest EmpCo exposure is not the chemistry, it is the copy. Search product pages, hangtags, collection names and filters for: green, eco-friendly, sustainable, conscious, climate neutral, carbon neutral. For each hit ask one question — can we point to specific evidence on that product? Where yes, a small edit making the evidence visible usually saves the claim. Where no, reword it.

Source: <https://www.bluesign.com/empco-what-brands-can-say>

- **Get your DWR status in writing from suppliers.** France's thresholds apply to fluoropolymers, and an EU-wide class-based restriction follows by 2029. Ask for test results rather than assurances.

Source: <https://projetcelsius.com/en/blog/pfas-ban-france-eu/>

- **Two event dates inside the next five days.** Lenzing and Kaihara debut the REMOD Collection — three TENCEL™ Lyocell fibre types for denim — at Kingpins Amsterdam on 14–15 October. Brightplus shows its bio-based PEF laminate at Performance Days Munich on 13–14 October.

Source: <https://www.globaltextiletimes.com/news/lenzing-and-kaihara-unveil-remod-collection-at-kingpins-amsterdam-bringing-tencel-lyocell-portfolio-to-denims-creative-forefront/>

- **Certify what you claim, and make it specific.** Leap at 91% and Leafy Leather at 99% show how precise the numbers now have to be. Under EmpCo an unqualified "bio-based" is a generic claim; a numbered composition line with a named certificate behind it is a defensible one.

Source: <https://www.biopreferred.gov/BioPreferred/>

Where published figures were absent — as with the Brightplus laminate — I have flagged it rather than estimated. Every claim carries a source link.

— Esther